

# Big DP & Big PRO: A unified account of reflexive and impersonal *se*

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**Abstract:** We argue that, despite the lack of an overt external argument in (most) impersonal/passive *se* clauses in Spanish, there is a syntactically projected external argument: an empty category PRO necessarily doubled by the pronominal clitic *se*. We unify all instances of so-called impersonal, passive and generic *se* as involving the same kind of external argument, whose interpretive qualities are determined by an operator. We further extend the same analysis to internal reflexive arguments that are also necessarily doubled by *se*, thus capturing the intuitive fact that PRO has anaphoric properties (Manzini 1983; Landau 2000; Kayne 2018; 2025). Our analysis has a major advantage, which is a uniform treatment of all the aforementioned instances of *se* as pronominal clitics that double the same type of argument. Our analysis thus avoids the need to posit complicated semantic values of different instances of *se*, and captures several distributional idiosyncrasies of the clitic *se*.

**Keywords:** implicit arguments; *se*; big DP; big PRO; impersonals; reflexives; Spanish

## 1 Introduction

In this paper, we offer a novel analysis of the external argument of Spanish impersonal *se* clauses (1) and reflexive internal arguments (2) which are doubled by what looks like the same clitic.

(1) *Se solicitan lavadores.*  
SE solicit.3PL washers  
'Washers are requested.'

(2) (Ella) *se lavó.*  
(she) SE wash.3SG.PAST  
'She washed herself.'

Clauses containing the impersonal clitic *se* have received substantial attention in the literature on the syntax, morphology, and semantics of Romance, as has the reflexive counterpart. We analyze both (1) and (2) as containing an empty category big PRO which is necessarily doubled by the clitic *se* within a 'big DP' structure (Uriagereka 1995). We unify all instances of so-called impersonal, passive and generic *se* under this analysis, as well as reflexive internal arguments that are also obligatorily doubled with *se*.

We provide empirical support for the presence of the impersonal external argument in Section 2.1. In Section 2.2, we describe the structure of the external argument of impersonal *se* clauses, adopting a 'big DP' analysis in which the clitic *se* doubles a thematic argument PRO. Section 3 extends the analysis of the external argument of impersonal *se* clauses to the internal argument of reflexive predicates, which we argue is structurally identical, and that the interpretation of reflexive internal arguments follows straightforwardly from this analysis. We offer a novel explanation of why the *se* clitic appears in these two seemingly disparate constructions, and we also explain the fact that impersonal/passive and reflexive *se* cannot cooccur with one another.

## 2 Syntactic projection of the impersonal external argument

Impersonal *se* clauses are mostly characterized by the lack of an overt external argument AGENT (though this is not without exception).

- (3) (#Alguien) se escribió una carta.  
(#someone)SE write.3SG.PAST a letter  
'A letter was written.'

In (3), the interpretation of *se* as an impersonal clitic is only possible if there is no overt external argument. If an overt external argument were to appear in a preverbal position—even an impersonal subject like *alguien* 'someone'—then *se* would no longer be interpreted as a marker of impersonality (as indicated by the '#' sign), and would instead be interpreted as a reflexive or aspectual clitic.

Despite the fact that the interpretation of an impersonal external argument is unambiguously present in impersonal *se* clauses, researchers have questioned the status of this understood external argument as being projected in the syntax (MacDonald 2015; Russo Cardona 2022, a.o.) or not (e.g., Saab 2020), perhaps due to the fact the external argument does not usually appear overtly

In this section, we motivate an analysis of a syntactically-projected external argument doubled by *se* in impersonal *se* clauses, which we take to be a thematic argument PRO that is necessarily doubled by the clitic *se* for purposes of licensing.

### 2.1 Tests

We begin the analysis of the syntactically-projected external argument by empirically demonstrating its existence. We use evidence of binding/control (2.1.1), agreement interaction effects (2.1.2), and Case restrictions (2.1.3) to show that the implicit AGENT of impersonal *se* clauses is projected in the syntactic derivation of the relevant utterances.

#### 2.1.1 Binding of elements that require a syntactic antecedent

Appropriating tests from Collins (2024) showing that there is a syntactically-projected external argument in English passives, we reach the same conclusions about impersonal *se* clauses in Spanish. These tests concern the binding of elements that require a syntactic antecedent. These elements include secondary depictive predicates (4) and PRO subjects of adjunct purpose clauses (5), with the latter being an adaptation of the famous English sentence from Mauner et al. (1995).

- (4) a. Se baila borracho.  
SE dance.3SG drunk.M.SG  
'It is danced drunk.'  
b. Se juega descalzo.  
SE play.3SG barefoot.M.SG  
'It is played barefoot.'
- (5) Se hundió el barco para PRO cobrar el seguro.  
SE sink.3SG.PAST the boat for PRO cover.INF the insurance  
'The boat sank in order to collect the insurance.'

In these examples, the interpretation of the bound elements unambiguously and straightforwardly corresponds to the interpretation of the understood AGENT of the impersonal *se* clause. For instance, in (5), the collector of the insurance in the embedded clause is clearly coreferent with the sinker of the boat. For these reasons, we do not analyze such cases as involving mechanism other than binding by the external argument, such as arbitrary control or sentential control (e.g., Williams 2015; Bhatt & Pancheva 2017), which involve no such straightforward connection between the interpretation of the bound element and the understood external argument of the matrix clause (indeed, sentences often used as counterexamples to the claim that a PRO subject of an embedded purpose clause require a syntactic antecedent, such as ‘Grass is green to promote photosynthesis’ (Williams 1985:310), aside from being marginal on some level, clearly do not involve the straightforward interpretive link between the AGENT of the matrix clause and the AGENT of the embedded clause that we describe here). For more discussion of the validity of these tests for diagnosing the presence of an external argument, we refer the reader to Collins (2024).

### 2.1.2 Agreement interactions

Further evidence for the syntactically-projected external argument in impersonal *se* derivations comes from agreement interaction effects with subject-verb agreement. Here, we focus on two important agreement restrictions seen with impersonal *se* clauses, which is the optionality of agreement with certain 3pl internal arguments (6), and the impossibility of agreement with 1/2p internal arguments (7).

- (6)        Se {censuró/            censuraron}        los documentos.  
              SE {censor.3SG.PAST/censor.3PL.PAST} the documents  
              ‘The documents were censored.’
- (7)        Se me        {censuró/            \*censuré}            a mí.  
              SE 1SG.CL {censor.3SG.PAST/\*censor.1SG.PAST} to me.  
              ‘I was censored.’

Regarding the person agreement restriction in (7), it should be noted that this restriction holds in every variety of Spanish to our knowledge. We take this agreement restriction to be a property of the fact that the THEME is first person.

We analyze this agreement restriction as a classic weak PCC effect (Bonet 1991; Ordóñez 2002; Béjar & Rezac 2003, a.o.) of more than one subject caused by the inability of subject-verb agreement to access a first- or second-person argument due to the presence of an intervening third person argument. We take this intervener to be the null impersonal external argument that the clitic *se* doubles. Interestingly, this is a PCC effect seen with subject agreement, which is crucially distinct from the variety of PCC effects seen with multiple object clitics in Romance (e.g., Bonet 1991). In fact, the data in (7) show the opposite of the object clitic PCC restriction in Romance in which the second in a series of two object clitics cannot be first- or second-person; instead, it is the postverbal subject argument that cannot be 1/2p. The facts that *se* clitics show subject-oriented PCC effects—and not the kind of PCC effects seen with multiple object clitics—are sympathetic to a view of *se* as a subject clitic, a point that we defend further on.

There are many extant analyses of these kinds of PCC effects (e.g., Coon & Keine 2021; Deal 2024; Storment 2025), and we believe that committing to one of these analyses in detail is beyond the scope of this paper; rather, the presence of the effect itself is sufficient to take as evidence of the syntactically-projected impersonal external argument, since PCC effects crucially arise from the interaction between more than one argument.

Additionally, we take the external argument to optionally serve as an intervener for number agreement with the THEME in (6). For an in-depth explanation of how a number-deficient argument could optionally serve as an intervener for number agreement, see Storment (2025). While there do exist alternative explanations of the agreement optionality with number (e.g., Ormazabal & Romero 2024), our explanation carries the advantage of reducing the number agreement optionality and the PCC effects to a single source; the aforementioned alternative explanations make no reference to the PCC effects and would presumably need to invoke different mechanisms to explain them.

We further see no motivation for claiming that the number agreement alternations mentioned here are themselves indicative of distinct underlying structures for each number agreement variant (e.g., Dobrovie-Sorin 1998). There is no clear interpretive distinction between each agreement variant shown in (6), for instance. Our analysis unifies these different agreement patterns as a single clause type, which, given the goal Minimalist theorizing to “eliminate unnecessary distinctions” (Roberts 2010:5), we consider an advantage of our analysis.

Thus, the optional intervention effects for number agreement and obligatory intervention effects for participant agreement with the internal argument THEME in impersonal *se* clauses serve as evidence of a syntactically-projected external argument. If there were no such intervening argument, we would expect these impersonal *se* clauses to pattern with unaccusatives, which select only a THEME argument and show no such agreement interaction effects.

### 2.1.3 Case and thematic restrictions

Our final piece of evidence comes from the fact that there is a strong Case restriction in impersonal *se* clauses (Ordóñez 2021). Impersonal *se* configurations are only possible with verbs that assign nominative Case to their external argument. To demonstrate this point, let us take two verbs which are similar in meaning and Theta-role assignment, yet differ in terms of the Case they assign to their external argument.

First, we have *aborrecer* ‘abhor’, which assigns nominative Case to its external argument EXPERIENCER and is licit in an impersonal *se* clause (8). We then have *disgustar* ‘dislike’, which assigns dative Case to its external argument EXPERIENCER as is not licit with impersonal *se* (9).

(8)        *Se aborrece el pecado.*  
              SE abhor.3SG the sin  
              ‘Sin is abhorred.’

(9)        \**Se disgusta el pecado.*  
              SE dislike.3SG the sin  
              *int*: ‘Sin is disliked.’

The pattern here is straightforward, as are its implications. Syntactic Case is assigned to syntactic objects, not the absence of syntactic objects. The clear Case asymmetry in (8)-(9) with predicates that have similar semantic values and assign the same EXPERIENCER Theta-role to their external arguments (which differ in Case assignment) clearly suggest that there is a Case restriction on the external argument of impersonal *se* clauses, which even more clearly suggests that there is a syntactically-active external argument in these derivations.

It must additionally be the case that the argument that *se* doubles is the highest thematic argument in the clause, as the internal argument of (9) has also been analyzed as bearing nominative Case, but cannot be an impersonal external argument, either. In other words, the argument that *se* doubles must be distinct from and is incompatible with any other argument that may receive nominative Case; see the further impossibility of *\*Se me disgusta* ‘I am disliked’, which follows from *se* doubling an empty category. In other words, *se* being a marker of nominative Case without doubling a null PRO argument is not sufficient to explain the nature of the thematic restriction.

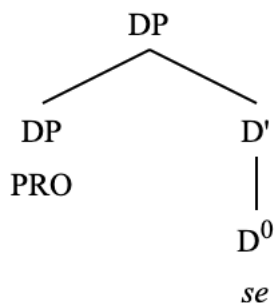
## 2.2 Describing the impersonal external argument

Having seen sufficient evidence that impersonal *se* clauses contain a syntactically active external argument, we can now move into a description of the structure, distribution, and interpretation of this argument.

### 2.2.1 Structure

We assume that the *se* of impersonal *se* clauses is a pronominal clitic that obligatorily doubles a (usually) null thematic external argument. For this account, we adopt Uriagereka’s (1995) ‘big DP’ approach to arguments that have undergone clitic doubling, in which the pronominal clitic appears as the head of a complex DP that takes the thematic argument in its specifier. This looks as follows.

(10) Big DP, big PRO doubled with impersonal *se*



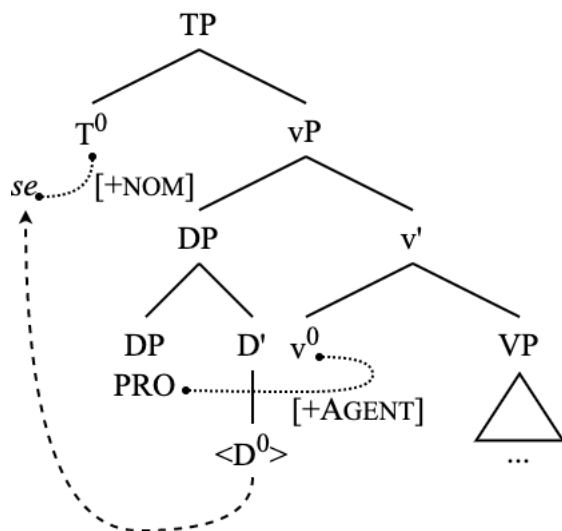
As is evident in (10), we take the thematic argument that *se* doubles to be an instance of big PRO, which is classically assumed to not receive Case (Chomsky 1981, *et seq.*). This analysis using big PRO as an element that does not receive Case and generally has a limited interpretation as an arbitrary and/or anaphoric element captures the important generalization that clitic doubling with *se* is obligatory in impersonal *se* clauses (i.e., the *se* clitic is necessary for the impersonal interpretation to be available), even though argument clitic doubling is optional in a variety of configurations in Spanish (Rivas 1977; Jaeggli 1982; Suñer 1988; Bleam 2000).

PRO does not receive Case (Chomsky 1981), nor does it seem to participate in subject-verb agreement or move into an EPP-position in a language like Spanish. For this reason, licensing via

clitic doubling is necessary. Clitic doubling has been analyzed as a means of licensing particular features of the doubled argument, including Case (Sportiche 1996, a.o.). In this spirit, we analyze the doubling of this PRO argument with the clitic *se* as a way to indirectly assign nominative Case to the external argument.

Thus, the big DP containing the big PRO is externally merged in the thematic external argument position—which we take to be Spec,vP—where an external argument Theta-role is assigned to the PRO. As PRO itself cannot receive Case, the pronominal clitic *se*, which is externally merged as the head of the big DP complex, moves into the inflectional domain (simplistically represented here as TP), where as a pronominal clitic it can be assigned Case (in this instance, nominative). See the following.

(11) Theta-role and Case assignment, big DP



In a sense, and to use a bit of antiquated terminology, *se* ‘absorbs’ Case here on behalf of the thematic argument PRO, and the two are related via starting out as a single constituent in the big DP configuration. This is necessary as PRO itself is not compatible with Case. This analysis is also compatible with the view of nominals containing PRO empty arguments more generally (Giorgi & Longobardi 1991).

The clitic doubling is necessary here—whereas it may be optional in some other configurations—because, without the clitic doubling, no part of the external argument would have been Case-licensed, and the verb would have failed to assign nominative Case to its external argument. This can be seen in the fact that, without the *se* clitic, only a referential external argument interpretation is possible. See the following.

- (12) a. Se arregla coches.  
           SE fix.3SG cars  
           ‘Cars are fixed.’  
       b. Arregla coches.  
           fix.3SG cars  
           ‘He/she fixes cars.’

This scenario can be contrasted with other configurations in which clitic doubling is optional, in which some other mechanism of Case-licensing may be available to the clitic-doubled argument DP, such as DOM with *a*, which is seen with clitic-doubled object DP, as in the following example from Bickford (1985:191).

- (13)        (*Le*)        da        corbatas *a* su        esposo cada Navidad.  
               (3SG.DAT.CL)give.3SG neckties to 3SG.POSS husband every Christmas  
               ‘He/she gives neckties to his/her husband every Christmas.’

The exact parameters of optionality in Spanish argument clitic doubling are well beyond the scope of this paper; we bring this issue up to make the point that clitic doubling of the impersonal external argument PRO is obligatory because, if there were no clitic doubling of the PRO, the derivation would not be licit due to the conflict between the inability of PRO to receive Case and the necessity of the verbs that participate in this construction to assign nominative Case to the external argument. Doubling of the external argument PRO with *se* resolves this conflict, so to speak, which is not seen with other clitic-doubled arguments such as pronominal and dative objects.

As such, the analysis of the thematic external argument of impersonal *se* clauses as involving a big PRO explains the obligatory presence of the clitic *se* in these clauses. Our analysis differs in this way from other analyses that have proposed a small *pro* impersonal external argument (e.g., Russo Cardona 2022; Collins 2024). We believe that the specification of the impersonal external argument in this way is attributable to crosslinguistic variation. If a related language were to have a small *pro* impersonal external argument that were able to receive Case in the absence of clitic doubling, we might expect clitic doubling with *se* to be optional or absent altogether, which seems to be the case in Brazilian Portuguese, as in the following (Carvalho 2016:61-2).

- (14)        A roupa (\**se*) lavou.  
               the clothes (\*SE) wash.3SG.PAST  
               ‘The clothes got washed.’

The big PRO of Spanish impersonal *se* clauses is associated with obligatory clitic doubling for the purposes of licensing the external argument. In the following section, we turn to a discussion of the interpretive qualities of this impersonal external argument, which we argue further endorse a view of the clitic *se* obligatorily doubling and coindexing a big PRO subject.

It must be the case, then, that *se* receives nominative Case (see the data from Section 2.1.3). In this way, impersonal *se* can be understood as a kind of nominative subject clitic (Cinque 1988; D’Alessandro 2007; Roberts 2010; Ormazabal & Romero 2024, a.o.).

There is a question here of why there is a nominative Case clitic in Spanish, which is certainly not the normal state of affairs for Spanish. Spanish can be contrasted in this way with Romance languages which do regularly make use of subject clitics (Palasis 2015; Pescarini 2022). In this view, *se* is unique among clitics in that it is a Spanish subject clitic. We can connect this uniqueness to the fact that in no other contexts does a big PRO appear part of the structural subject of a finite clause. Since the *se* clitic is connected to nominative Case, and subject clitics are not normally licensed in Spanish, we see that there is variation in the way that nominative Case—and subject licensing in general—is realized in Spanish, which we connect to observations about the variation

of Spanish subject licensing and the availability of nominative Case from Etxepare & Gallego (2020), namely that nominative Case assignment is not the only strategy for licensing external arguments in Spanish, though we argue that it must be available for the licensing of the clitic that doubles the impersonal big PRO since it cannot be licensed in another way.

### 2.2.2 Interpretation

It has been well-documented that there are several restrictions on the interpretation of null external arguments that are obligatorily doubled with *se*, and that these restrictions within Romance are a point of crosslinguistic variation (Suñer 1990; D'Alessandro 2007; Armstrong & MacDonald 2021; Ordóñez 2021, a.o.).

We follow previous work in assuming that the external argument of impersonal *se* clauses is necessarily controlled by a generic or existential operator in Spanish (e.g., Suñer 1990; Ordóñez 2021), and may in other Romance languages such as Italian be controlled as well by a first-person plural operator (D'Alessandro 2007). We additionally argue that the analysis of this external argument as big PRO naturally fits in with the null-operators approach to the interpretation of the impersonal *se* external argument better than it were a small *pro* DP.

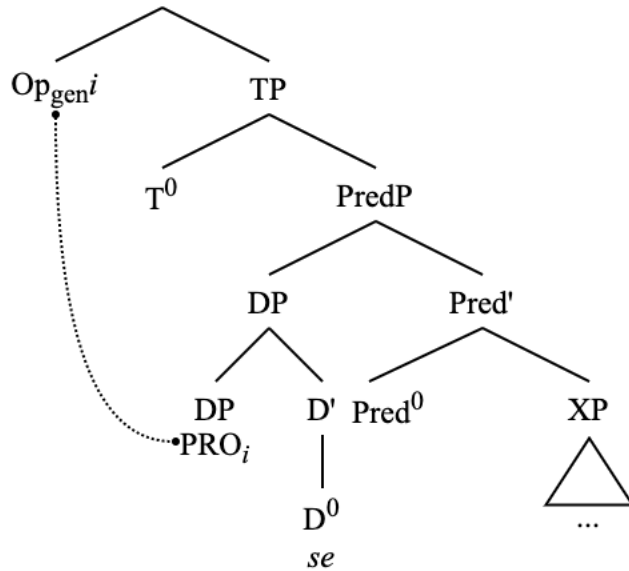
For this section (and, indeed, for the entire paper), we assume a theory of semantic interpretation in which semantic values are assigned to syntactic structures (e.g., Chomsky 2021; Collins 2024 a.m.o.). As such, we assume that semantic relations such as control—as well as other interpretive restrictions that are sensitive to structural configurations—directly follow from relations between elements that are established in the narrow syntax (Chomsky 1981; Landau 2000, a.o.).

We do not adopt an alternative conception in which a powerful system of formal semantics is capable of assigning interpretations freely to any given element in any position. Therefore, we do not adopt or consider, for instance, purely semantic notions of control (Jackendoff 1972; Williams 1985) or argument structure (e.g., Williams 2015). One immediate issue with these such approaches that are entirely grounded in formal semantics is that they raise “immediate and serious questions of restrictiveness” (Collins 2024:156). For instance, if the interpretative mechanisms of argument structure and control are entirely divorced from syntactic structure, much additional work has to be done to ensure that the ‘wrong’ interpretation is not assigned to any argument in any position, which we consider an unnecessary complication to the theory of the architecture of the grammar. For additional discussion of these issues of restrictiveness and the necessity of grounding interpretation in syntactic structure, we refer the reader to Chap. 10 of Collins (2024), as well as assumptions on the modularity of grammar inherent to frameworks such as the Strong Minimalist Thesis (SMT) (Chomsky 2021; 2024).

Returning to the issue at hand, we assume that a generic operator binds the external argument in generic contexts (Suñer 1990). Our analysis departs from Suñer’s, though, in that we assume that the bound external argument is a big PRO, not a small *pro*. This looks as follows.

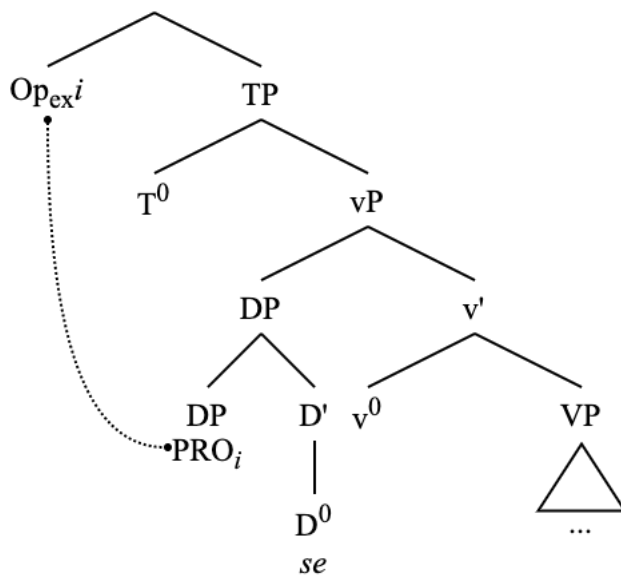


- (15) a. Aquí se es inteligente.  
 here SE is intelligent  
 ‘People are intelligent here.’  
 b. Structure with generic operator



In episodic contexts, we assume that an existential operator binds the external argument (e.g., Cinque 1988; Chierchia 1995). See the following example from Ordóñez (2021:150).

- (16) a. Ayer, se estudió el tema de la guerra civil.  
 yesterday, SE study.3SG.PAST the topic of the war civil  
 ‘Yesterday, the civil war was studied.’  
 b. Structure with existential operator



There is an additional restriction on the availability of the existential operator, which is that it is only possible with transitive, unergative verbs: that is, there is a connection between the availability of the existential interpretation and the external argument being located in Spec,vP. See the ungrammaticality of episodic existential interpretations with copulas and unaccusative verbs, again from Ordóñez (2021:150).

- (17) a. \*Ayer se estuvo contento.  
yesterday SE was.3SG happy  
*int*: ‘Yesterday, one was happy.’  
b. \*Ayer se desapareció a las 7am.  
yesterday SE disappear.3SG.PAST at the 7am  
*int*: ‘Yesterday, one disappeared at 7am.’

In other words, the existential operator is only available to bind the PRO of the external argument in certain thematic/structural contexts. For a more detailed explanation of this cooccurrence restriction, we refer the reader to Ordóñez (2021).

As for the first person plural interpretation of the impersonal *se* subject, we see that this is available in some Romance languages, such as Italian (D’Alessandro 2007:143), but is not available in Spanish. See the following.

- (18) Si è stati invitati anche noi. (Italian)  
SE be.3SG been.PL invited.PL also we  
‘We too were invited.’  
(19) \*Se ha sido invitados también nosotros.  
SE have.3SG been invited.PL also we  
*int*: ‘We too were invited.’

We assume that the difference between Spanish and Italian here can be attributed to a crosslinguistic difference in the availability of the first-person plural operator in the lexicon of the relevant language. There is, however, a more nuanced discussion to be had on the relation between impersonal pronouns and first-person-plurality in Romance more generally: see French *on*, Brazilian Portuguese *a gente*, and the *si* of many Italian varieties. We leave these issues in detail for future work.

Our analysis of the external argument of impersonal *se* clauses as containing a big PRO fits in with the null-operator-based explanation of the interpretation of this external argument with fewer stipulations than an alternative, which is to say that the bound external argument is a small *pro* subject (Suñer 1990). The interpretation of PRO is necessarily parasitic on an element that binds it, which in these cases have been identified as the operators. There is no such necessity for the interpretation of small *pro*. Therefore, to make a subject small *pro* necessarily coreferent with an operator requires extra stipulations on the nature of the subject argument, especially in a language like Spanish where null subjects are freely available with fewer interpretive restrictions. Conversely, it is the nature of big PRO to have such an interpretive restriction. We additionally do not see any advantages to the claim that the operators bind *se* itself because it is more parsimonious

to assume that operators bind an empty category in these situations, and that pronominal clitics by nature double thematic arguments that are structurally reflected elsewhere in the clause.

An independent piece of evidence in support of the null-operators approach, however, is what happens when there is an overt external argument. See the following example of the possibility of expressing the external argument with a *by*-phrase (Sánchez-López 2002; MacDonald 2017), which we take to be the overt realization of the external argument (Collins 2005; 2024) (indeed, the fact that the agent appears overtly in this way shows that the *se* clitic itself cannot be the thematic external argument).

- (20) Esta obra se escribió por un autor totalmente desconocido.  
 this work SE write.3SG.PAST by an author totally unknown  
 ‘This work was written by a totally unknown author.’

In these configurations, even the *by*-phrase is subject to interpretive restrictions. See the following interpretive restriction on indefiniteness.

- (21) \*Esta obra se escribió por Cervantes.  
 this work SE write.3SG.PAST by Cervantes  
*int*: ‘This work was written by Cervantes.’

Crucially, there are no such interpretive restrictions on the external argument of a standard periphrastic passive.

- (22) Esta obra fue escrita por {Cervantes/mí/un autor desconocido}.  
 this work be.3SG.PAST written by {Cervantes/me/an author unknown}  
 ‘This work was written by {Cervantes/me/an unknown author}.’

These data suggest that the operators are still present in impersonal *se* clauses and impose interpretive restrictions on the external argument, even when it is overtly expressed with a *by*-phrase. In the case of (20)-(21), the existential operator is only compatible with an indefinite external argument in the episodic context. Therefore, the *by*-phrase of (20)-(21) must also involve the big PRO in its structure.

In this section, we have demonstrated that the big PRO analysis of the external argument of impersonal *se* clauses fits in with the null-operators approach to the interpretation of the external argument. The presence of the interpretive restrictions on *by*-phrases provide additional support for the null-operators approach. An additional advantage of this analysis is that impersonal, ‘passive’, and generic *se* clauses do not need to be treated as entirely separate constructions. They are hence unified as having the same impersonal argument, whose interpretation is determined by the operator. In this way, we reject the idea that there are distinct underlying structures and derivations for so-called impersonal versus passive *se*, or nominative versus accusative *se* (Dobrovie-Sorin 1998) Following work such as Ormazabal & Romero (2024), we do not see any evidence that these different interpretations correspond to entirely distinct structures.

The analysis of *se* as involving clitic doubling of an empty anaphoric element big PRO is more parsimonious than assuming that *se* itself is a thematic argument (Dobrovie-Sorin 1998) or a kind

of voice head that does not project an external argument at all (Saab 2020), because these alternative explanations involve positing a very complicated semantics for the *se* clitic itself. Attributing the main interpretive qualities to these clauses to the clitic itself is especially problematic under the view that argument clitics in Romance do not themselves carry any semantic values (Angelopoulos 2019; Angelopoulos & Sportiche 2021).

We do not discuss other interpretive diagnostics for the presence of big PRO such as the ‘Lebeaux effect’ (Lebeaux 1984; Borer 2020), as the Lebeaux effect only applies to instances of uncontrolled arbitrary PRO, though we argue here that the instances of PRO in impersonal *se* clauses are controlled by operators.

### 3 Reflexive *se*

Thus far, we have shown arguments for a view of the external argument that *se* doubles in impersonal contexts as a big DP containing a thematic big PRO, whose interpretation is entirely parasitic on the properties of the empty operator that binds it. The *se* clitic of the big DP complex is obligatorily present, which we have connected to the issue of a big PRO being unable to receive Case. Descriptively, the situation of having an argument whose interpretation is entirely parasitic on an element that serves as its antecedent and is also obligatorily doubled with *se* is strongly reminiscent of another type of argument in Romance, which is reflexive (23a) and reciprocal (23b) internal arguments.

- (23) a. Daniela *se* ama.  
           Daniela SE love.3SG  
           ‘Daniela loves herself.’  
       b. Los hombres *se* besan.  
           the men       SE kiss.3PL  
           ‘The men kiss each other.’

We now extend our analysis of the external argument of impersonal clauses as a big DP containing a big PRO and the clitic *se* to the structure of the internal argument of reflexive/reciprocal predicates as well (for other analyses of reflexive nominals as containing a big PRO, see Kayne 2018; 2025). This analysis explains the interpretive properties of reflexive/reciprocal predicates quite well in line with the Minimalist assumptions of this paper, and captures the empirical fact that both impersonal and reflexive/reciprocal clauses involve the clitic pronoun *se*. Additionally, this analysis of reflexives as involving a big PRO draws upon a precedent in the literature for analyzing big PRO as an anaphoric element (Manzini 1983; Landau 2000; Kayne 2018; 2025).

#### 3.1 The Pronominal Agreement Condition

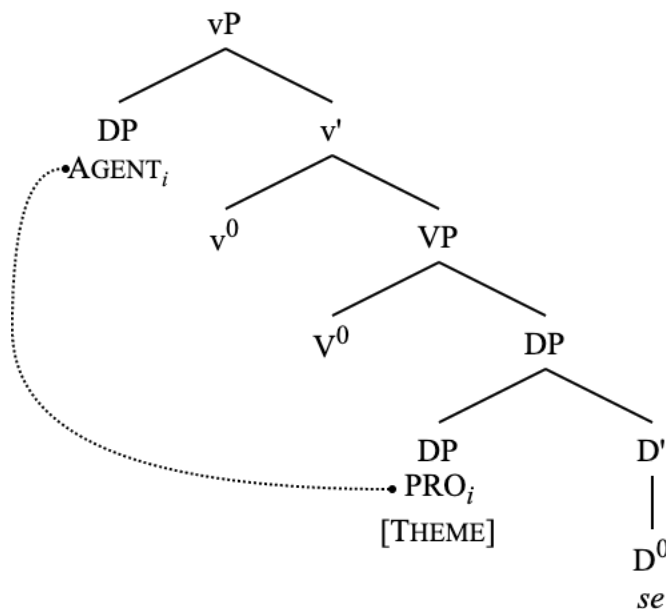
Quite intuitively, reflexive/reciprocal anaphors must match in their features and interpretation with their antecedents. Descriptively, this can be captured as the Pronominal Agreement Condition (PAC) (Collins & Postal 2012). See the following.

- (24) *Pronominal Agreement Condition* (Collins & Postal 2012:182)  
       If P is a nonexpletive pronominal, then for all  $\phi$ -features F of P for which P is not inherently valued, P agrees with F in some source.

A technical implementation of the PAC is perhaps less straightforward, especially one that does not come with significant complication to the theory. For a reflexive anaphor that is asymmetrically c-commanded by its antecedent, this could be done with some version of upward Agree (e.g., Bjorkman & Zeijlstra 2019). Analyzing an anaphoric pronoun as containing a big PRO, however, can capture the generalizations of the PAC without needing to invoke significant complications to a model of agreement.

We can conceive of the binding of big PRO as a relation that holds between the element PRO and its closest c-commanding nominal antecedent that establishes featural and interpretive coreference. If the underlying motivation for the establishment of the binding relation is driven by Minimal Search (e.g., Chomsky 2021; 2024), then no extra technological stipulations are needed in the narrow syntax to establish control. Using the same structure as the impersonal external argument for reflexives, this looks as follows.

(25) Binding of a reflexive THEME by an AGENT antecedent



As a relation driven by Minimal Search, this kind of antecedent binding can be interrupted by an intervener. As such, this binding relation is expected to obey locality conditions like relativized minimality (Rizzi 1990). Here, the analysis makes predictions.

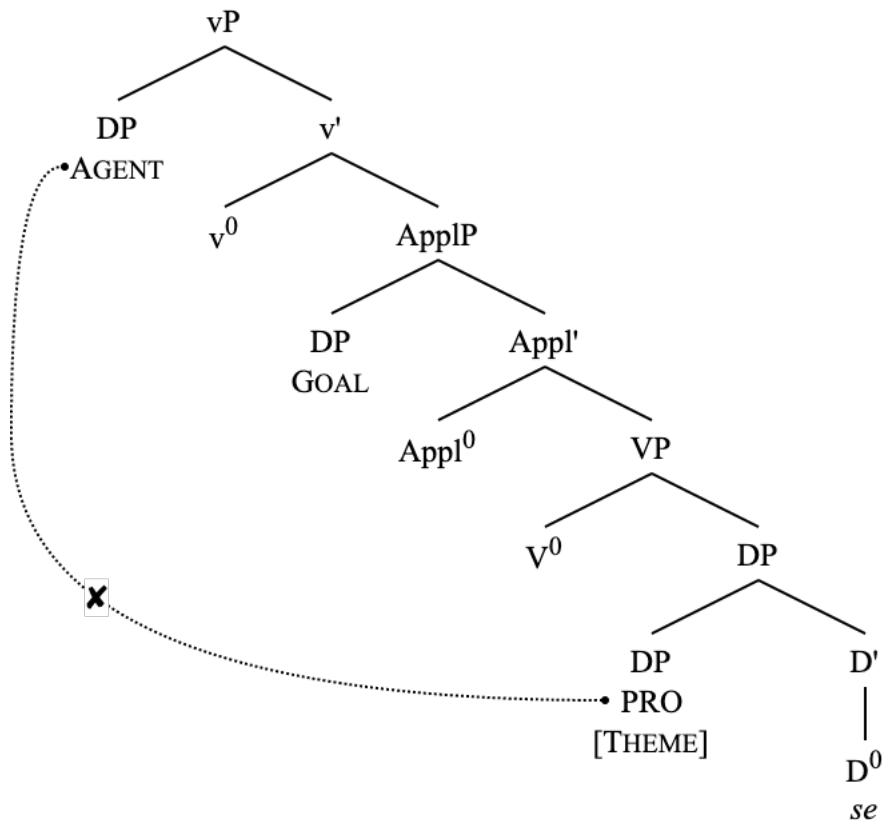
Assuming a basic uniform hierarchy in the projection of thematic arguments in which AGENTS are externally merged above GOALS which are externally merged above THEMES (e.g., Baker 1988; Collins 2024), it is the case that a GOAL argument consistently intervenes between a THEME and an AGENT argument in their base positions. Thus, a binding relation between a big PRO THEME and an AGENT should be interrupted in the presence of an intervening GOAL.

As such, we can observe in Spanish ditransitive structures in which a reflexive clitic is potentially ambiguous between a GOAL and a THEME that the non-reflexive clitic must be marked as accusative.

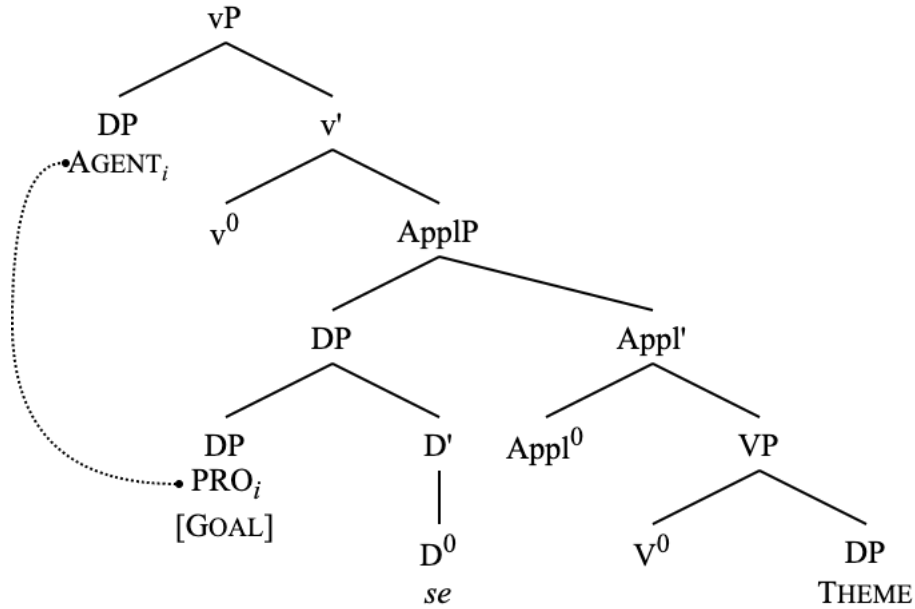
- (26) Me {1o/ \*1e} recomendé.  
 1SG.CL {3SG.M.ACC.CL/ \*3SG.DAT.CL} recommend.1SG.PAST  
 ‘I recommended myself to him.’ (*lit*: ‘I recommended myself him.’)
- (27) Juan se {1a/ \*1e} asignó (a sí mismo).  
 Juan SE {3SG.F.ACC.CL/ \*3SG.DAT.CL} assign.3SG.PAST (to self same)  
 ‘Juan assigned himself to her.’ (*lit*: ‘Juan assigned himself her.’)

These data indicate that the reflexive in these structures must be the GOAL, as accusative morphology is exclusive to clitics that double THEME arguments. Thus, a reflexive THEME which is coreferent with the AGENT in the presence of a GOAL is blocked (28), while a reflexive GOAL in the presence of a THEME is free to be bound by the AGENT without intervention (29).

- (28) Binding of reflexive THEME by AGENT blocked by GOAL



- (29) Binding of reflexive GOAL by AGENT not blocked by THEME



Thus, the analysis of reflexive/reciprocal anaphors as containing a big PRO which must be bound/controlled under Minimal Search explains these locality conditions.

Our analysis additionally captures the fact that reflexive *se* is paradigmatic: i.e., it can be realized with any of the person/number features of the external argument that serves as its antecedent (1/2/3p, sg/pl). The lack of paradigmaticity for impersonal *se*, which is only ever bound by a phi-deficient operator, is what creates the PCC effects for subject-verb agreement in impersonal clauses (Section 2.1.2). There is no agreement intervention effect with reflexive *se* clitics because reflexive *se* always matches in the features of the external argument antecedent. For the sake of space, we do not expound on this issue here.

### 3.2 The *se* cooccurrence restriction

Another fact about reflexive predicates is that they cannot cooccur with an impersonal *se* clitic. This can be seen in the fact that only one *se* clitic is permitted per clause, and, in the case of inherent reflexive verbs (or verbs which strongly favor a reflexive predicate reading), only the reflexive reading of the *se* clitic is available, even with an adjunct that is conducive to an impersonal/generic reading, such as *por aquí* ‘around here’. See the following.

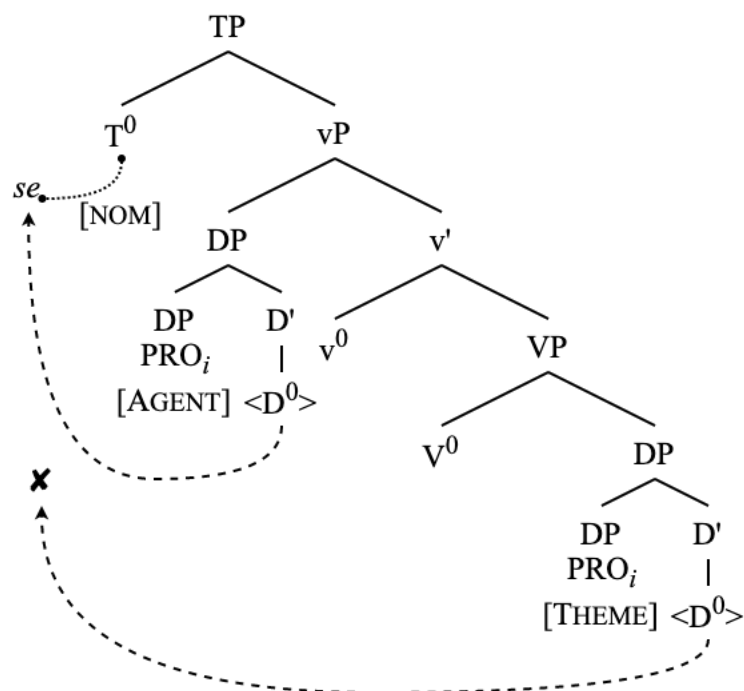
- (30) Se (\*se) lava las manos por aquí.  
 SE (\*SE) wash.3SG the hands for here  
 ‘He/she washes his/her hands around here.’ (\*‘People wash their hands around here.’)
- (31) Se (\*se) queja por aquí.  
 SE (\*SE) complain.3SG for here  
 ‘He/she complains around here.’ (\*‘People complain around here.’)

Two important generalizations stand out here. First, only one *se* clitic is permitted per clause. Second, in cases of potential ambiguity with reflexive predicates, the impersonal interpretation of

*se* is not available. These generalizations follow from the account of both the impersonal external argument and the reflexive internal argument involving a big PRO inside a big DP structure.

The fact that only one *se* clitic is permitted in a single clause suggests that impersonal and reflexive *se* compete for the same position. Due to this cooccurrence restriction, only one argument is able to be licensed via doubling with *se* at a time. Given that both the impersonal external argument and the reflexive internal argument contain instances of big PRO that would fail to be licensed without doubling by *se*, a clause containing both the impersonal external argument and a reflexive internal argument runs into the issue of having too many PRO arguments needing to be licensed via *se*, with only one available position for a single clitic. Analyses of these constructions in which different types of *se* arguments are freely available—e.g., both nominative and accusative *se* (Cinque 1988; Dobrovie-Sorin 1998)—are not able to explain these cooccurrence restrictions, both in terms of why more than one *se* clitic cannot appear in a single clause, and why one interpretation should take precedence over another in certain cases.

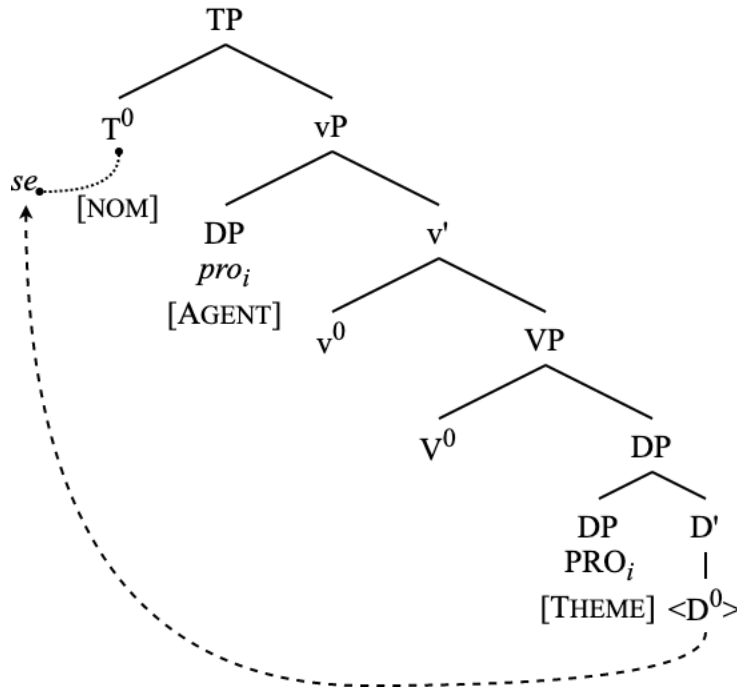
(32) Inability of a reflexive internal argument to be licensed



If the external argument of a reflexive predicate is referential, however, there is no such issue.



(33) Reflexive internal argument licensed



Thus, a given *se* clause cannot be simultaneously impersonal and reflexive, and predicates that necessarily involve reflexive arguments cannot cooccur with an impersonal PRO external argument, for both arguments cannot be licensed at the same time. It is not impossible to have a reflexive and impersonal interpretation anywhere, as reflexive internal arguments can cooccur with an overt impersonal external argument such as *uno* ‘one’ (which itself does not require doubling with *se*). It is only the case that reflexive internal arguments are incompatible with the impersonal external argument containing big PRO described in this paper.

In this system, it follows that reflexive clitics should also be an indication of nominative Case. While this is intuitively unexpected since reflexive internal arguments are straightforwardly objects, it is consistent with the fact that reflexive clitics also do not show object-oriented PCC effects within clitic clusters (see the grammaticality of *Te me raccomandaste* ‘You recommended yourself to me’).

We additionally believe that the movement of the reflexive/reciprocal clitic *se* into a nominative Case position is compatible with analyses of ‘transitive’ reflexive predicates in Romance as unergative structures (e.g., Sportiche 2014), since the only Case value reflected in these structures is nominative.

#### 4 Conclusion

To conclude, our analysis of impersonal and reflexive *se* constructions has cast both instances of *se* as doubling of a big DP argument containing a big PRO, with the doubling serving the purpose of allowing the big-DP structure to be assigned Case. A major advantage of our analysis is that it captures the intuitive fact observation that *se* has the distribution, interpretation, and form of a pronominal clitic in both configurations in which it is used, which we take to be derived via the doubling of a thematic argument.

In addition to unifying the structure of reflexive and impersonal *se*, our analysis also does not require a formal distinction to be drawn between impersonal (or ‘nominative’) and passive (or ‘unaccusative’) *se* (e.g., Dobrovie-Sorin 1998), as both can be handled as instances of the same empty category being doubled by the clitic whose potential interpretive differences come down to the properties of the operator that binds it. We leave aside the question of how to handle Romanian.

We have provided sufficient motivation for the empty-category analysis of the impersonal *se* argument, both in terms of the interpretive properties of this argument as well combinatoric observations such as the fact that there is a nominative Case restriction, and that the external argument can in fact be overtly expressed as a *by*-phrase (which also must conform to the interpretive restrictions of an operator).

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